



Q

What pH level is generally considered safe to prevent the growth of *Clostridium botulinum* in home-canned foods?



ANSWER

4.6 or below

FUN FACT

Foods with pH 4.6 or below are called high-acid foods and do not support botulism growth.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values



Q

Why must herbs and vegetables stored in oil be refrigerated or frozen when made at home?



ANSWER

To prevent the growth of Clostridium botulinum in the oxygen-free oil environment

FUN FACT

Commercial garlic-in-oil mixtures are acidified to safely store at room temperature.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil



Q

What is a critical food safety practice to avoid cross-contamination during home food preservation?



ANSWER

Wash knives and cutting boards with hot soapy water after contact with raw meat

FUN FACT

Separating raw and ready-to-eat foods prevents bacterial spread.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness



Q

What should you do if you find a home-canned jar with a bulging lid and spurting liquid when opened?



ANSWER

**Discard the contents
immediately without tasting**

FUN FACT

Bulging lids often indicate dangerous bacterial growth such as botulism.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

For low-acid canned vegetables, what processing method is recommended to ensure safety?



ANSWER

Pressure canning at specified times and pressures

FUN FACT

Low-acid foods need pressure canning because spores survive boiling temperatures.

Source: SP 50-714 Science of food preservation



Q

Why is it important to follow tested home canning recipes exactly without altering ingredients or proportions?



ANSWER

Changes can affect acidity or heat penetration, risking unsafe food

FUN FACT

Modifying recipes can unexpectedly enable bacterial growth.

Source: SP 50-714 Science of food preservation



Q

What is the recommended headspace for home-canned high-acid foods like fruits or pickles?

FOOD SAFETY



Adults

ANSWER

1/4 inch to 1/2 inch

FUN FACT

Proper headspace allows air to escape and creates a good vacuum seal.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values



Q

What precaution should you take when home canning tomatoes in a boiling water bath?



ANSWER

Add bottled lemon juice or citric acid to increase acidity

FUN FACT

Adding acid is a safety step to prevent botulism in tomato canning.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

How long should home-canned vegetables or meats be boiled before tasting as a safety measure?



ANSWER

10 minutes plus 1 additional minute per 1,000 feet elevation

FUN FACT

Boiling helps destroy botulinum toxin if present before tasting.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

What is the 'danger zone' of temperatures where harmful bacteria grow most rapidly during food preservation?

FOOD SAFETY



Adults

ANSWER

40°F to 140°F

FUN FACT

Keeping foods out of this temperature range prevents bacterial growth.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness



Q

What is the safe minimum internal temperature to cook whole poultry including turkey to ensure food safety?

FOOD SAFETY



Adults

ANSWER

165°F

FUN FACT

Use a food thermometer to be sure poultry is safely cooked.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



Q

How soon should eggs or egg dishes be refrigerated after cooking or preparation?



ANSWER

Within 3 hours

FUN FACT

Refrigerate eggs promptly to reduce Salmonella risk.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness



Q

What characteristic of mold on home-canned food always indicates that it is unsafe to eat?



ANSWER

Visible mold growth on the surface

FUN FACT

Never taste or reuse foods with mold to avoid toxins.

Source: SP 50-934 USDA molds on food



Q

Why is refrigeration necessary for homemade flavored oils like pesto or garlic-in-oil mixtures if not acidified?



ANSWER

To prevent anaerobic growth of *C. botulinum* bacteria

FUN FACT

Low acidity plus oil creates perfect conditions for botulism without refrigeration.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil



Q

What is the effect of altitude on home canning processing times?



ANSWER

Processing times must be increased at higher altitudes

FUN FACT

Water boils at lower temperature with altitude, needing longer cooking.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

Which symptom is a warning sign to discard home-canned food immediately without tasting?



ANSWER

Food spurting liquid when opening the jar

FUN FACT

Spurting liquid indicates gas build-up from unsafe bacterial growth.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

Why should leftovers be reheated to 165°F before eating?



ANSWER

To kill bacteria that may have grown during storage

FUN FACT

Use a thermometer to check reheated food safety.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness



Q

What is an important step before handling food to reduce chances of contamination?



ANSWER

Washing hands with soap and warm running water

FUN FACT

Handwashing is the simplest way to prevent foodborne illness.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness



Q

Why are tomatoes considered borderline between high-acid and low-acid foods in canning safety?



ANSWER

Because some varieties have pH near 4.6 which may allow botulism if not acidified

FUN FACT

Adding lemon juice increases acidity for safer boiling water canning.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism



Q

What is the recommended storage method for homemade flavored oils if you cannot use them within four days?



ANSWER

Freeze them in airtight containers

FUN FACT

Freezing preserves the flavor and safety of homemade oils long term.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil